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Indian Diversity and Global Migrations

> ‘India is a geographical and economic entity, a cultural unity amidst diversity, a bundle of contradictions held together by strong but invisible threads.’
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> —Jawaharlal Nehru[1]

Why is India such a diverse country? Why do Indians speak so many languages, celebrate a number of festivals, devour assorted pickles and buy a variety of fairness creams?

Is it because of successive waves of migration which, for example, explain the stunning human diversity seen in a New York subway train? Or is it a diametrically opposite reason: one of group isolation preserved over a long time and forced into unification only in recent times? After all, Papua New Guinea, a small country of less than 10 million people in the Pacific Ocean, hosts more languages than India, a country of over a billion people, as human traits evolved separately with minimal contact between the islanders.[2]

It is important to recognize these two separate routes to diversity observed in any region: one through migration and the other through isolation and the *lack* of migration. In this context, a popular and enduring view of India is that it was, and is, a land of low spatial mobility, that it was essentially a land of around half a million self-sufficient villages lying